

Once Upon a Doodle.

Point your camera at a drawing. Get back a film.

Snap a photo of a sketch — a kid's crayon dragon, a napkin doodle, anything — and hit one button: **Tell a Story**. The app reads what's actually in the drawing, writes a story around it, and returns an illustrated sequence that plays back as a narrated short film. Same character, same wonky lines, now moving.

12h live-stream sprint

Web app · any stack

Mobile-first · camera required

The Insight

Every fridge door is a graveyard of stories nobody ever told. A child draws a purple dog with six legs, explains an entire universe about it for four minutes, and then the paper goes in a drawer. The drawing already contains the story — the parent just has no way to see it. AI image tools solve the wrong half of this: they turn prompts into pictures. This turns *a picture into a story*, with the child's own character kept in the leading role.

The pitch in one line: your kid's drawing was always a movie — this is the projector.

The Pipeline — One Button, Four Steps

01

Capture

Camera or upload. Auto-crop the paper, clean the lighting, keep the lines.

02

Read

A vision model names what's there: characters, colours, mood, style.

03

Write

A 5–8 beat story starring that exact character. Age-appropriate, warm, short.

04

Show

One illustrated frame per beat, narrated, playing full-screen like a film.

The user never sees a prompt box. One photo, one button, one output. Everything in between is the app's job.

What The User Actually Sees

- **Opens on the camera.** No menu, no onboarding, no sign-up.
- **One button: "Tell a Story."** Nothing else on the screen competes with it.
- **A generation screen that entertains** — the drawing animating in, beat titles appearing as they're written.
- **Frame 1 is always the original drawing.** The story starts from their paper, not from AI art.
- **Full-screen player** — auto-advancing frames, narration, tap to pause, swipe to step through.
- **One share button** that produces a link anyone can open — grandma included.

Style Rule — Keep The Kid's Hand

The single thing that makes this magical instead of generic: the generated frames must look like the *same* drawing, not like a polished illustration inspired by it. Wonky proportions, crayon texture, wrong colours — all preserved. If the output looks like professional children's-book art, the demo dies.

How to hold consistency: extract a written character sheet from the vision pass ("purple dog, six legs, one ear bigger, drawn in thick crayon on lined paper") and inject it verbatim into every frame prompt, alongside a fixed style clause. Where the model supports it, pass the original photo as an image reference on every generation. Cheapest reliable trick: composite the original drawing directly into frame 1 and let the style anchor from there.

■ Definition of Done — 12 Hour MVP

If every row is true and it runs in a phone browser, the build ships. Nothing else counts.

REQUIREMENT	PASSES WHEN...
✓ Camera + upload	A phone can take the photo in-app, or pick one from the roll. Both paths reach the same screen.
✓ One button	"Tell a Story" is the only control needed. No prompt box, no settings, no style picker.
✓ It reads the drawing	The story references what is actually on the paper — the right animal, the right colours. Judges test this with their own sketch.
✓ 5+ illustrated frames	A beginning, middle and end. Frame 1 is the original drawing. The character is recognisably the same throughout.
✓ It plays like a film	Full-screen playback with auto-advance and narration audio. Not a grid of images, not a scroll of text.
✓ Under 2 minutes	Capture to first frame in under 120 seconds, with a progress state that never looks frozen.
✓ Shareable link	Every story gets a permanent URL that opens and plays for someone who has never used the app.
✓ Deployed public URL	Judges open it on their own phone from a link or QR code. Localhost is a fail.

■ Latency Is The Product Risk

Six images plus narration will not return in five seconds, and a spinner for ninety seconds is a dead demo. Design the wait as part of the show.

- **Stream the story text first** — the title and beats land in seconds and give people something to read.
- **Generate frames in parallel**, not in sequence, and show each one the moment it lands.
- **Start playback at frame 2.** Frame 1 is their drawing and is already on screen.
- **Narrate while rendering** — text-to-speech runs alongside image generation, never after.

■ Identity, Data & Sharing

- **No login to make a story.** Guest by device ID. Google login only when they want the story saved to a shelf.
- **Kids' faces and drawings are sensitive.** Stories are private by default; sharing is an explicit, per-story action.
- **Wholesome by construction** — pin the story prompt to gentle, age-appropriate output and filter the input image.
- **stories** — id, owner_id, source_image_url, title, status, is_public, created_at
- **frames** — id, story_id, index, image_url, caption, audio_url
- **players / users** — id, handle, avatar_url, provider, device_id
- **The Shelf** — a per-user gallery of past stories, re-openable and re-shareable.

■ Stretch & Traps

- **Real motion** — feed each frame to a video model for 3-second clips, stitched into an actual film.
- **Pick a voice** — narrator options, or the parent records the narration themselves.
- **Multi-drawing casts** — photograph three drawings, get one story with all three characters.
- **Download as MP4** so it can go straight to the family group chat.
- **Losing the original.** If the drawing isn't in the output, the emotional hook is gone.
- **Beautiful, generic AI art.** Polish is the enemy here.
- **Long stories.** Six frames. Sixty seconds. Nobody watches more on a phone.
- **A prompt box.** The moment you add one, it's just another image generator.
- **Serial generation** behind a blocking spinner.